his rivals; he marched thousands of Taira-loyal warriors into Kyoto, put Go-Shirakawa under house arrest, and then forced the young Emperor Takakura to abdicate in favor of Takakura's baby son Antoku—Kiyomori's own grandson.[2]

Taira Kiyomori now stood at the crest of his power. He was grandfather of the Emperor, master of the Cloistered Emperor, virtual ruler of Japan. His climb had taken over twenty years. "As Prime Minister," the epic history *Tales of the Heike* tells us, "Kiyomori now held the entire realm within the four seas in the palm of his hand." His ultimate victory lasted less than a year; and then he died, of a sudden severe fever, in March of 1181.[3]

Already, the backlash was building.

Its architect was one of the survivors of the Heiji Disturbance: Minamoto Yoritomo, son of the beheaded Yoshitomo. Thirteen at the time of the Disturbance, Yoritomo had been exiled by the victorious Kiyomori, rather than executed. The act of mercy had been a strategic error. In his banishment, says the *Gukansho,* Yoritomo "had been thinking deeply about world affairs." He was now in his early thirties, and for two decades had been gathering allies and planning his revenge.[4]

He began in the southern cluster of volcanic islands known as the Izu Islands, where he had lived since his father's death, and traveled up the eastern coast. This was traditionally Minamoto territory, and he was able to collect volunteers as he went. In a series of small battles—some defeats, but more victories—his army slowly gained strength, until he was able to establish himself strongly in the coastal city of Kamakura.

